Qa'eda from a new sanctuary for them in Afghanistan to our interests in the region and at home.

Internationally we are seeing a weakening of resolve among our friends and partners. Polls in many NATO countries show public attitudes are divided on bringing troops from their countries home immediately or remaining until the country is stabilized. In all but the US and the UK, majorities called for withdrawal as soon as possible.

It is clear that there is a lack of an overall, overarching strategic vision to reinvigorate the effort to attain unified, reachable goals.

This year has been the deadliest for US and coalition troops since the invasion of 2001.

The most immediate threat is from the anti-government insurgency that has grown significantly in the last two years. Attacks against Afghan military and police forces have surged. Some success has been achieved in targeting Taliban leadership, but significant areas of Afghanistan, particularly in the south have been lost to friendly control.

Some of our allies believe the mission is failing and several NATO members are wavering in their troop commitments, offsetting the strong involvement of Britain, Denmark, Poland, Canada, Australia and the Netherlands among others.

A failure of NATO in Afghanistan would damage the future of the organization itself.

Realizing an Afghanistan that is stable and secure and free of influence from radical, Islamic forces is a core objective. Taliban and al Qa'eda maintain close links.

There is an acute need for international coordination on both the military and civilian side. Separate military commands with some overlapping missions complicate the process as does the lack of a senior civilian leader. The recent appointment of Ambassador Kai Eide of Norway was a helpful solution to that critical issue.

Military and especially police training are lagging as are counter narcotics efforts and dicial and penal reform.

Provincial Reconstruction Teams (PRTs) fielded by many governments have separate reporting channels back to their capitals and there is no unified field theory on how they should operate, be coordinated or accomplish their missions.

A recent report in the Washington Post concluded that: ''While the (US) military finds success in a virtually unbroken line of tactical achievements, (US) intelligence officials worry about a looming strategic failure.''

Six years after the fall of the Taliban Government in Afghanistan the country is still facing a fundamental crisis of governance. Without an honest, sustainable government there can be little effective development and even less political legitimacy. The country has ''a stunning dearth of human capital'' and a number of leaders, often in the provinces, are considered to be serial human rights abusers by much of the population. This shakes confidence in the rule of law and democracy and overall governance in critical ways. Underpaid civil servants are asked to undertake dangerous counter narcotics missions and easily fall prey to bribery and corruption in return.

The public looks to the government not only for housing and health care, roads and schools, but just as much if not more for security and justice. At present the government annot do this and that leads neighbors, aid donors and troop contributors to hedge their bets.

Former US Commander, LTG Karl Eikenberry, has said the greatest long-term threat is not the resurgence of the Taliban but ''the potential irretrievable loss of the Government of Afghanistan.''

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